



BANDEEP SINGH

CLASSES FOR MASSES: Guru Madhvi Mudgal (left) and Madhup

GANDHARVA MAHAVIDYALAYA AN ENDLESS DUET

As you enter the serene campus of Gandharva Mahavidyalaya in Delhi, melodious voices, the strumming of sitars and the beats of the tabla engulf you. In one corner, you can see the principal of the Mahavidyalaya, Madhup Mudgal, giving his take on the nature of the monsoon raga Miya ki Malhar to his disciples, while in the other, students practice the delicate mudras of Odissi dance. Welcome to the calm and tranquil atmosphere of a modern-day gurukul, where students, be it a seven-year-old boy, a 45-year-old housewife or a 34-year-old autorickshaw driver, get a rare chance to learn Indian dance and music, through performance.

The Mahavidyalaya took seed when musicologist Pandit Vishnu Digambar Paluskar was convinced that musicians did not enjoy a high status in society and decided to integrate the art form into the daily lives of the people. His idea was to start an institution, where children from different strata of society could be trained in classical dance and music forms. So was born a gurukul system of education, where students could stay

in close proximity to the teachers. Once the foundation was made, the first Gandharva Mahavidyalaya came up in Lahore on May 5, 1901, followed by one in Mumbai in 1908 and another in Delhi in 1909.

As Mudgal points out, "Paluskar envisioned the future to be replete with musical evangelists and missionaries." Paluskar used notations for the traditional compositions and published books, which could act as reference guides. What initially started as a small dream with three institutions, is today 150 Mahavidyalayas across the country. Apart from classical music, the institution has a curriculum for classical dances, too. "We have kept the fee as low as possible. And if someone is not able to pay even this amount, we teach them free of cost," says Mudgal, who has spent almost his entire life at the Mahavidyalaya. The fee for an elementary course starts at Rs 500 per month. From the classes to the masses, Gandharva Mahavidyalaya is a movement that has found a rare beat in today's times.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

"What is great about it is that apart from producing musicians, it produces music lovers."

PANDIT JASRAJ, VOCALIST